Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Peter

1 Peter 1:1

- To the elect: The apostle Peter begins his letter by reminding suffering Christians of their special status because of God's action for them (1:2).
- who are exiles of the Dispersion: An exile is a person taken from his or her homeland to live in a foreign place. Peter uses this image to remind Christians that they live in a world shaped by values and ways of life that oppose Christ.
- Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia: These were Roman provinces in the region that is now Turkey. Peter may list them in the order that a messenger would follow when delivering the letter to the churches.

1 Peter 1:2

according to the foreknowledge of God the Father: In the Bible, God's foreknowledge refers to his knowledge and loving purpose from the beginning. It means that God chose his people in advance and set his love on them before they knew him (compare Romans 8:29; 11:2).

1 Peter 1:3

new birth: This is a way of describing Christian conversion (compare John 3:1–13; James 1:18; 1 John 2:29; 3:9; 4:7; 5:1, 4, 18). This Greek word, which occurs again in 1 Peter 1:23, frames the message of 1:1–25.

1 Peter 1:3–9

In most New Testament letters, a section of thanks or praise follows the greeting. Peter praises God because his mercy gives new spiritual life. This life creates hope for the future, even during difficult times.

1 Peter 1:4

The language of inheritance often refers to what God has promised his people. It originally applied to the land of Israel (see Deuteronomy 3:28). Later, inheritance came to mean the people of God and God's presence with them (see Psalm 33:12; Ezekiel 44:28). In the New Testament, the inheritance is the spiritual benefits and eternal salvation that God promises to his people (see Ephesians 1:11; Hebrews 9:15).

1 Peter 1:5

- For the salvation: In the New Testament, salvation often means the final rescue from sin and death when Christ returns. This hope encourages Christians to persevere until the end (see also 1:9, 10; 2:2; 4:18).
- ready to be revealed: The future revealing of God's salvation stands in contrast to the present time, when God and his purposes are not fully seen (see also 1:7, 13).

1 Peter 1:7

- proven character of your faith ... refined by fire: Faith, like gold, becomes purer when tested or refined by fire.
- may result in praise, glory, and honor: This could mean that God will give praise, glory, and honor to faithful Christians. It could also mean that their faithful lives will bring praise, glory, and honor to God.

1 Peter 1:9

salvation of your souls: The Greek word translated souls often refers to the whole person and not just to some part or aspect of the person (Matthew 20:28; Mark 8:35). Salvation affects our whole person, not the inner person only.

1 Peter 1:10–12

this salvation: The prophets in the Old Testament spoke about this salvation long before it came. Even the angels desire to understand it more fully.

1 Peter 1:11

- trying to determine: The prophets in the Old Testament received many messages about the future. But they did not know exactly when the promised salvation would come or how God would bring it.
- The Greek phrase translated the time can also mean what person. The prophets understood that the Messiah would come and that he would suffer before he was glorified. But they did not know who the Messiah would be.

1 Peter 1:12

long to look: The same Greek word is used of the disciples when they looked into the empty tomb of Jesus (Luke 24:12; John 20:5, 11).

1 Peter 1:13

prepare your minds for action (literally gird the loins of your mind): In Peter's time, a man had to tuck the hem of his long robe into his belt before he could work or run.

1 Peter 1:13–21

New birth and the hope of salvation call Christians to live as God's people. They must turn away from the values of the world and follow the holiness of God, who redeemed them.

1 Peter 1:15–16

"Be holy, because I am holy": This phrase appears often in Scripture. It emphasizes that God's people must be holy like God (see Leviticus 11:44–45; 19:2; 20:7; also Ezekiel 20:12; Ephesians 1:4; 1 Thessalonians 4:3; Revelation 22:11).

1 Peter 1:17

Christians belong to heaven. Because of this, they live in this world as foreigners with different values and with a clear purpose from God. Their heavenly identity calls them to live faithfully and responsibly in the places where God has put them, while looking forward to the fullness of life with God (1:1; see Philippians 3:20).

1 Peter 1:18

A ransom is a payment made to set a captive free. In the ancient world, slaves could sometimes pay a ransom and gain their freedom. Christ's death is the ransom that God used to set people free from sin (1:19).

1 Peter 1:19

a lamb without blemish or spot: The Jewish Passover lamb had to be without any defect (Exodus 12:5). Christ fulfills the meaning of the Passover. He was without defect or sin (compare Hebrews 4:14–16; 7:26–28).

1 Peter 1:20

With Christ's coming, God is fulfilling Old Testament promises of redemption, and the last days have begun.

1 Peter 1:22

have a genuine love for your brothers (Literally, must have brotherly love): See study note on 5:9.

1 Peter 1:22–2.3

After calling believers to live holy lives (1:13–21), Peter explains how they must show love to one another as fellow Christians.

1 Peter 2:2

Christians have been "born again" and should be like newborn babies, who naturally and regularly crave pure spiritual milk (1:23). In other places in the New Testament, milk (in contrast to solid food) represents basic Christian teachings (1 Corinthians 3:2; Hebrews 5:12–13). But this does not mean that the people Peter wrote to were new believers. Here, milk most likely refers to God's word in general.

1 Peter 2:3

now that you have tasted that the Lord is good: These words come from Psalm 34:8. Peter quotes this psalm again in 1 Peter 3:10–12.

1 Peter 2:4

rejected by men but chosen and precious in God's sight: This refers to Psalm 118:22, which is quoted in 1 Peter 2:7.

1 Peter 2:4–10

Throughout this letter, Peter encourages suffering believers by reminding them of the great honor they have from God. In this paragraph, he describes the Christian community as a new temple that is built on Christ. He also shows that they share in the blessings God promised to his covenant people.

1 Peter 2:5

- God's people form the spiritual house or temple where God lives (1 Corinthians 3:16). Jesus compared his body to a "temple" (John 2:19–22). The church is called "the body of Christ" (Ephesians 4:12). God no longer reveals himself in one place but in and among the people who belong to him and praise his goodness (see 1 Peter 2:10).
- As God's holy priests in the new covenant, Christians offer not animal sacrifices but spiritual sacrifices such as praising God, praying, and doing good (see Romans 12:1; Hebrews 13:15–16).

1 Peter 2:6–8

These verses include three quotations from the Old Testament. Each one describes Christ as a kind of stone:

- The first quotation calls him the cornerstone on which God builds the new temple (2:6).
- The second quotation calls him the cornerstone that people rejected, but God raised up to become the most important stone in his plan to save the world (2:7).
- The third quotation calls him the stone that makes people stumble when they refuse to believe (2:8).

Jesus quotes Psalm 118:22 in Matthew 21:42. Paul quotes both Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16 in Romans 9:33.

These three Old Testament passages were likely brought together very early in the church. Early believers probably used them as a combined witness to the identity and importance of Jesus the Messiah.

1 Peter 2:8

to this they were appointed: It is not clear whether God appointed these people to unbelief, or whether God appointed them to suffer condemnation because they refused to believe.

1 Peter 2:9

Peter uses descriptions of the Israelites in the Old Testament to refer to his mainly non-Jewish (Gentile) audience (see, for example, Exodus 19:5–6). By doing this, he shows that they are truly God's people in the time of the new covenant, just as all Christians are.

1 Peter 2:11

foreigners and exiles: Christians belong not to this world but to the kingdom of heaven (see 1:1, 17).

1 Peter 2:11–12

These verses connect the first part of the letter with what comes next. They can be seen as the end of the first section or the beginning of the second section. In these verses, the writer states the main theme of the letter. Christians live among people who may not accept their faith, and they need to live out the message of the good news. When they do this, they can help lead other people to the Lord.

1 Peter 2:12

on the day He visits us: The Greek phrase behind this wording can also be translated "on the day of visitation." In the Greek Old Testament, day of visitation refers to a time when God comes to act in judgment against his enemies (Isaiah 10:3; Jeremiah 6:15).

1 Peter 2:13

During Peter's time, the Roman emperor was the king. Christians were suffering under the government and would soon face harsher persecution under Emperor Nero.

1 Peter 2:13–3.7

This section focuses on the key instruction to submit to all human authority. Peter applies this instruction to several relationships:

- Christians should accept the authority of those in government (2:13–17).
- Christian slaves should accept the authority of their masters (2:18–25).
- Christian wives should accept the authority of their husbands (3:1–6).

Peter appears to follow an early Christian use of the traditional household code. This code gave a series of instructions for different members of a household. Similar examples appear in Ephesians 5:21–6:9, Colossians 3:18–4:1, 1 Timothy 5:1–6:2, and Titus 2:1–10.

1 Peter 2:14

to punish those who do wrong and to praise those who do right: Compare Romans 13:3–4.

1 Peter 2:17

- The brotherhood: See study note on 5:9.
- fear God, honor the king: Peter might be thinking about the balanced statement that Jesus gave on a Christian's duty to both God and the government (see Matthew 22:21).

1 Peter 2:18

- Many slaves in the Roman Empire held responsible positions and earned a decent income. However, most slaves were treated harshly, and all slaves lacked legal status and basic rights.
- with all respect (literally with all fear): Peter might be urging slaves to fear God (see 2:17; compare 1:17) or fear the master's punishment. However, he often uses this kind of language to describe the respectful attitude that Christians should show toward others (3:16).

1 Peter 2:18–20

A slave was legally bound to a master and could not change his or her situation. In contrast, a modern employee has the right to stop working for an employer who is cruel. Some employees, however, may not be able to leave their jobs. In those cases, Peter's advice to slaves can also apply to employees today.

1 Peter 2:21–25

- There is no clear change in who Peter is addressing in this passage. However, the general tone of these verses shows that they apply to all Christians.
- These verses might include an early Christian hymn or confession about Christ (2:22–25). They focus on the sufferings of Christ for human salvation or redemption, using language mainly from Isaiah 52:13–53:12.

1 Peter 2:24

- He Himself bore our sins: This phrase refers to Isaiah 53:4, 11–12.
- By His stripes you are healed: The physical suffering of Christ has freed us from slavery to sin (compare Isaiah 53:5). The apostle Matthew uses similar language from Isaiah 53:4 to describe the physical healings Jesus performed (Matthew 8:17).

1 Peter 3:1

- Submit yourselves to: Wives are instructed to recognize that God has appointed the husband as head of the relationship (see 2:13; Ephesians 5:22–25). In the ancient world, submission often meant obedience (see 1 Peter 3:6). God also intends the husband to lead in a loving and respectful way (3:7; see Ephesians 5:25–30). Peter focuses especially on wives whose husbands do not believe in Christ and who may oppose their wives' faith.
- without words: Peter encourages Christian wives to influence their husbands through respectful and appropriate behavior.

1 Peter 3:1–7

The last of Peter's three teachings about accepting authority speaks to wives and husbands (2:13–3:7; compare Ephesians 5:21–33; Colossians 3:18–19).

1 Peter 3:3–4

braided hair or gold jewelry or fine clothes: Peter is not saying that Christian women must avoid all forms of decoration. Instead, he teaches that their beauty should not come from clothing or jewelry but from the inner beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit. See also 1 Timothy 2:9–10.

1 Peter 3:6

- And called him lord: See Genesis 18:12. Peter sees this way of speaking as a sign of Sarah's general attitude of respect toward Abraham.
- refuse to give way to fear: Christian wives who were married to unbelieving husbands were often pressured, both subtly and openly, to give up Christian principles and values. Peter urges them to continue to do what is right.

1 Peter 3:7

- In the same way: Like slaves and wives, husbands also have specific responsibilities in the household (2:18–3:6).
- as a delicate vessel: Peter was likely referring to a woman's physical strength and possibly her lower social status in that society. Because women were usually physically weaker than men and often had less power to protect themselves, the husband had the responsibility to care for and protect his wife.
- fellow heirs of the gracious gift of life: The husband's role as head must be balanced by the truth that men and women have equal status before God (see also Galatians 3:26–29).
- A husband's prayers are hindered if he does not give special honor to his wife (compare James 4:3).

1 Peter 3:8–12

Finally: This is the last in a series of instructions to different groups (2:13–3:12). Here, all Christians should respond to other people with love, both believers and unbelievers (3:8; 3:9–12).

1 Peter 3:9

so that you may inherit a blessing: By blessing others, we receive a blessing from God.

1 Peter 3:10–12

Peter emphasizes the connection between a person's conduct and the blessing that God gives by quoting Psalm 34:12–16. This psalm was important in early Christian teaching (see also 1 Peter 2:3; Hebrews 12:14). The passage teaches believers to control their speech, resist evil, and do good. It also highlights God's promise to bless those who obey him.

1 Peter 3:13

In general, people do not want to harm someone who is doing good. However, Christians sometimes suffer even when they do good (3:14; see 1:6; 4:12–19).

1 Peter 3:13–17

This short paragraph emphasizes how Christians should respond to suffering by following Christ's example (see 3:18).

1 Peter 3:14–15

- "Do not fear what they fear; do not be shaken": See Isaiah 8:13, where God urges the prophet to fear only the Lord.
- sanctify Christ as Lord: By showing deep respect and obedience to Christ, they will no longer fear the people who persecute them.

1 Peter 3:18

He suffered physical death (literally death in the flesh), but he was raised to life in the Spirit (or in spirit). Flesh and spirit are often contrasted in

Scripture (for example, Romans 7:5–6; 8:2–11). In this passage, flesh refers to ordinary human life, and the Spirit refers to the new realm that began through Christ's death and resurrection. Christ died in the old realm and was brought to life in the new realm.

1 Peter 3:18–22

As in 2:21–25, Peter again points to Christ as an example for believers who suffer. Christ was righteous, yet he suffered (3:13–17). His unique work for us reminds suffering Christians that their hope and confidence rest on a secure foundation.

1 Peter 3:19–20

This difficult passage has been widely interpreted in three ways:

1. One interpretation says that these were the spirits of people who had died, and that Christ preached the good news to them after his resurrection. However, the New Testament does not support the idea that people can hear the good news or respond to it after death. Because of this, it is not likely that spirits in this passage refer to the spirits of dead people.
2. A second interpretation understands 3:19–20 as describing Christ preaching through Noah to the people who lived in Noah's time. These people are now spirits in prison. This interpretation would explain the reference to people in the days of Noah in 3:20. However, it does not fit well with the main discussion about Christ's death and resurrection in 3:18.
3. In the third interpretation, the spirits in prison are evil spiritual beings. Jewish tradition, based on Genesis 6:1–4, taught that many angels rebelled during the time of Noah (see also Jude 1:6; 1 Enoch 6–10). In this view, Peter is saying that Christ announced his victory over these evil spiritual powers after his resurrection (compare 1 Peter 3:22).

1 Peter 3:20

only eight souls: These were Noah, his wife, their three sons, and the sons' wives (Genesis 6:18; 8:18).

1 Peter 3:21

- symbolizes the baptism: Peter might mean that, just as the water lifted the boat that saved Noah and his family, baptism brings believers into salvation. Or he may mean that, just as Noah and his family passed through water to reach safety, Christians pass through the waters of baptism as part of their salvation. A third possibility is that, just as the water in Noah's day judged sin, the water of baptism shows the washing away of sin for Christians.
- Peter does not mean that water baptism saves a person regardless of that person's inner attitude. He explains that baptism saves only as a response to God from a clean conscience (or an appeal to God for a clean conscience). In this way, he makes clear that only people who exercise faith toward God will benefit from baptism.

1 Peter 3:22

All the angels, authorities, and powers accept his authority: In the ancient world, many people believed that spiritual beings had a direct effect on life on earth. Christians needed to remember that Christ has already won his victory over these spiritual powers. This means that we do not need to fear anything in the spiritual world (compare 3:14).

1 Peter 4:1

since Christ suffered in His body: Peter introduced this idea in 3:18. He now explains its importance in Christian life. In our own physical suffering, we should imitate Christ's attitude (see 2:21–24). Our suffering with Christ shows that we have identified with him (see Romans 8:17). Those who identify with Christ experience the victory over the power of sin that he won on the cross (Romans 6:1–10).

1 Peter 4:1–6

Peter urges Christians to make a definite separation from their former sinful way of life. Christ freed us from that way of life through his suffering.

1 Peter 4:3

the Gentiles: Peter uses this term from his Jewish background to describe those non-Jews who do not have a relationship with God.

1 Peter 4:6

Peter refers to people who are now dead but heard the good news about Jesus when they were alive. He is not teaching that people have a chance to repent after death. If these people responded with faith when they heard the message, they can trust God. Even though they had to die like all people, they will live forever with God in the Spirit.

1 Peter 4:7

The end of all things is near: With the coming of Christ, the "last days" predicted by the Old Testament prophets had begun (see 1:10–12). The next event in

God's plan to save people is the second coming of Christ. His return will bring an end to the world as we know it. This end could come at any time. Therefore, Christians must always be ready for it (see also Philippians 4:5; James 5:8; Revelation 1:3; 22:10).

1 Peter 4:7–11

With this paragraph of final instructions, Peter brings the third main part of the letter to a close (3:13–4:11).

1 Peter 4:8

By its nature, love chooses to overlook the sins that other people commit against us (see Proverbs 10:12; Matthew 18:21–22; 1 Corinthians 13:4–7). Peter might also mean that when we show love, we reveal our relationship with Christ. This loving attitude "covers" our own sins and leads to their forgiveness (see Luke 7:47).

1 Peter 4:10

- manifold grace of God: This refers to the variety of spiritual gifts God has given to followers of Jesus. See Romans 12:6–8; 1 Corinthians 12:1–31; Ephesians 4:7–16.
- use (literally manage) whatever gift: Christians are like managers. They have been trusted by God, their Master, with gifts to be used to bring glory to him.

1 Peter 4:11

so that in all things God may be glorified through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory and the power forever and ever. Amen: This doxology (a short hymn of praise) has led some people to think that one original letter of Peter ended here and that another letter was later added to it. Doxologies in the New Testament do appear at the end of letters (Romans 16:25–27; Philippians 4:20; Hebrews 13:21; 2 Peter 3:18; Jude 1:24–25). Doxologies also appear at the end of major sections within letters (Romans 11:36; Galatians 1:5; Ephesians 3:21; 1 Timothy 1:17).

Since there is no textual evidence for two separate letters, it is better to understand this doxology as marking the end of a major section of the letter.

1 Peter 4:12

do not be surprised: Christians, especially those trying to live in a way that pleases God, should expect hostility from this world that is full of sin (see John 16:33; Acts 14:22; Romans 8:17; Philippians 1:29).

1 Peter 4:12–19

Peter gives Christians one final instruction about how to face the trials that will surely come.

1 Peter 4:13

Christians are called to suffer with Christ in order to be glorified with him (see also Romans 8:17).

1 Peter 4:14

If you are insulted for the name of Christ, you are blessed (literally, you are blessed when people criticize you): This verse reflects the teaching of Jesus in Matthew 5:11–12.

1 Peter 4:16

Although the evidence is limited, it is likely that the name Christian (compare Acts 11:26) first served as a simple label used by those who did not follow Jesus. They used it to summarize what they believed were the strange religious practices and immoral behavior of those who followed Jesus.

1 Peter 4:17

God's judgment is often described as beginning with God's own household, meaning his people. This judgment serves to purify them (Jeremiah 25:29; Ezekiel 9:5–6; Malachi 3:1–6).

1 Peter 5:1–4

Elders were the spiritual leaders of the early churches (see also Acts 14:23; 20:17; 1 Timothy 5:17–19; Titus 1:5; James 5:14). By calling himself a fellow elder, Peter shows he shares their responsibilities and the guidance he offers them.

1 Peter 5:1–14

Peter concludes the letter with directions to:

- elders (5:1–4),
- younger people (5:5), and
- the entire church (5:5–11).

He then gives final greetings and ends the letter (5:12–14).

1 Peter 5:2

Be shepherds of God's flock: The word pastor comes from the New Testament image of a shepherd tending his flock.

1 Peter 5:5

young men: This might refer to a group of ministers who were still learning or who helped the elders in different ways. However, it most likely refers simply to the younger people in the church (see, for example, 1 John 2:12–14).

1 Peter 5:9

- your brothers: Here, the Greek word adelphoi refers to people, both male and female, who are members of the same family.
- throughout the world: Persecution was not limited to the churches in Asia Minor. Christians faced persecution in many places, in different ways and with different levels of intensity, wherever the good news about Jesus Christ was preached. Peter reminds his audience of this to comfort them and to encourage them to follow the example of those who had already endured suffering with faith.

1 Peter 5:10

a little while: Sufferings in this life may seem to never end, but they last only a short time when compared with the eternal glory believers will share with God (compare 1:6; Romans 8:18; 2 Corinthians 4:16–18).

1 Peter 5:12

- Through: This word identifies Silvanus as the amanuensis. An amanuensis is a person who writes down words as another person speaks or directs.
- Silvanus: Silvanus is also known by the shorter name Silas. Both names refer to the same individual. He was a close colleague of Paul after the council in Jerusalem (Acts 15:40; 16:19; 17:10, 14–15; 18:5; 2 Corinthians 1:19; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1).

We do not know how Silvanus later joined Peter in Rome. He may have traveled with Paul or followed him at a later time (Acts 27:1–28:31).

1 Peter 5:13

- Babylon was probably a symbolic name for Rome. Like Rome, Babylon was a great city and the capital of a large empire. In the 500s BC, Babylon ruled much of the ancient Near East.

Babylon was also the empire that burned Jerusalem and took many Israelites to live in Babylon as captives. Because of this history, many Jews saw Babylon as the center of a world that opposed God's people. For this reason, the book of Revelation uses Babylon as a metaphor for Rome, or as a code word that pointed to Rome. Peter probably used the name in the same way.

- Mark, also called John Mark, was another co-worker of the apostle Paul. He wrote the Gospel of Mark, which many people believe is based on Peter's teachings.

1 Peter 5:14

a kiss of love: See study note on Romans 16:16.